



Turning to fad diets may be tempting to those looking for a dramatic drop in weight. But do they work?

BY SMITA TRIPATHI

IT'S BEEN NEARLY two years since the pandemic started. Two years with most of us glued to our computer screens, binge watching Netflix and stress eating with hardly any exercise. Little wonder, there has been an increase in the number of obese people in the country. As per the National Family Health Survey (NFHS) findings in November last year, the percentage of overweight women rose from 20.6 per cent to 24 per cent while in men the number increased from 18.9 per cent to 22.9 per cent over the last five years.

Turning to dieting may be tempting for those looking for a quick fix. Now more than ever before one is spoilt for choice with a variety of dieting options—think Keto, or the splendidly-named Caveman Diet. But do they work? While fad diets focus on reducing calories, the results can be actually counter-intuitive. According to research, eating fewer calories can lead to hormonal changes that may increase appetite and make people crave higher-calorie foods. Some fads even cut out entire food groups, such as gluten, wheat or dairy, which contain nutrients needed for good health. “Any diet that asks you to completely remove any one food group, be it proteins, fats or carbohydrates, is unhealthy. We need all important food groups. We just have to figure out their proportions right. It doesn’t mean that any one of them is dispensable. If they are asking you to remove it, that’s a red flag,” says Delhi-based nutritionist Kavita Devgan, author of *The Don’t-Diet Plan*.